WEIGHT
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Setmelanotide

Injected peptide that switches on the melanocortin 4 (MC4) receptor, a brain hunger-control receptor



CLASS
Peptide

STUDIED FOR
Rare genetic and brain-injury obesity

HUMAN EVIDENCE
Small trials; FDA approved

US STATUS
FDA approved (Imcivree), rare obesity only

STUDIED FOR

- **Gene-based obesity** — HUMAN
- **Bardet-Biedl syndrome** — HUMAN
- **Hypothalamic obesity** — HUMAN
- **Hunger** — HUMAN

Not for common obesity. The label says it is not approved for common (polygenic) obesity and would not be expected to help there.

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

FDA APPROVED
LEVEL 5 OF 5

- Small trials: conditions are rare
- POMC/LEPR: 10 and 11 people, open-label
- TRANSCEND: 120 people, placebo-controlled

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Effect in Alström syndrome
- PK over 65 or in liver disease

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Setmelanotide ▶ MC4 receptor ▶ Hunger, fullness ▶ Lower food intake

- **MC4 receptor agonist,** with 20-fold less activity at MC3 and MC1 (label)
- **MC4 receptors** in the brain help regulate hunger, fullness and energy use
- **Based on nonclinical evidence,** may restore MC4 pathway activity
- **Weak MC1 action** in skin pigment cells darkens the skin in many people

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE
About 11 hours (Imcivree label)

ROUTES STUDIED
Injection under the skin, once daily

PHARMACOKINETICS
Peak about 8 hours; broken down into small peptides

SOLD AS
Prescription injection (Imcivree)

MONITORED IN TRIALS
Skin and moles, mood; adrenal and sodium issues in HO

SPORT (WADA)
Not on the 2026 list

REGULATORY

FDA	Approved: Imcivree, 2020; later uses added
EMA	Authorised orphan medicine (Imcivree, 2021)
WADA	Not prohibited

REFERENCES

1. FDA, Imcivree prescribing information, Apr 2026
2. Clément et al., POMC and LEPR Phase 3 trials, Lancet Diabetes Endocrinol, Dec 2020
3. Miller et al., TRANSCEND, N Engl J Med, Jul 2026

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